

your buddies in a strategic war is an intoxicating experience. Right now only Vikram is online, so it's a one on one game. "I remember playing 3 hours of monopoly and scrabble with my family. It used to be quite tedious. Now with *Command and Conquer* and *Counter-Strike*, I have a lot more variety in terms of new challenges and people to play with."

Vikram's ageing TNT2 graphics card cannot handle all the requirements of the high-end games, but he has no intention of upgrading his graphics card yet. "Let ATi and nVidia have a price war first with their next generation cards! Besides, a graphics card is low in my priority as I use my PC more for communicating with my friends abroad."

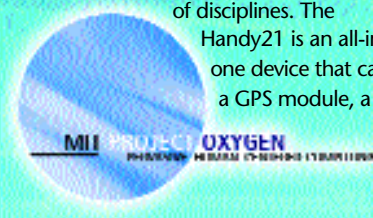
Play time

Entertainment for the Kumars
 Hema comes online to remind Roop of the family dilemma that was the cause of the squabble at breakfast—evening entertainment. Should they a) watch the movie running at Regal cinema or b) rent a DVD and watch it over dinner? Roop reads up a few reviews of *Minority Report* online and decides to drop it. "I still rely primarily on input from friends and co-workers for advice on these sort of things, but if I'm surfing and I see a movie or a restaurant that's received a glowing review, my odds of checking it out go up considerably." He makes a call to his neighbourhood DVD rental store for the latest DVD and stops to pick it up on the way home. "I like DVD movies. They have far superior sound and video

Project Oxygen

Imagine being logged onto a computer all the time, no matter where you went, or what you did. The computer would always run in the background, unobtrusively and seamlessly, forming an integral part of your daily life, like an element as pervasive as oxygen. That's the idea behind MIT's \$40 million Project Oxygen, which attempts to make us all nodes on the network, reachable any time, any place.

The project consists of four components that use techniques borrowed from a variety of disciplines. The Handy21 is an all-in-one device that can be a GPS module, a two-



way radio, a television, a pager, and a hand-held computer rolled into one. The Enviro21 is a stationary unit that enables computers to monitor our activities and body movements through infrared cameras. The N21 network links you to the World Wide Web and Natural Speech lets you communicate directly with the devices using voice commands.

Oxygen lets the network know where you are, and what kind of a device you are using at any given time. Suppose you are outside, walking the park, with a headphone and a microphone attached, the network innately knows the best way to reach you. This dramatic new project will help in organising our complicated lifestyles, but the revolution also raises some troubling privacy issues.

quality, are easier to store, and you don't have to rewind them!"

Back home, Hema is searching for the recipe for Avial, a south Indian delicacy. "I use the Net for surfing once in a while, but usually only to send e-mail to our relatives. Now that we have a Web cam, we can have a face-to-face chat with our relatives abroad—seeing them in person is such an amazing feeling," she gushes. The family gathers together at 7.30 pm for an early dinner, when Roop delivers his final observations.

"For what it's worth, technology has drastically changed the way I do things. For example, the yellow pages are sitting

in a corner of my house collecting dust, since I use the Internet to search for local businesses. I research products online and use the Internet to check whether a business carries a particular item I want instead of calling them personally. In fact, if a company doesn't have at least a rudimentary Web site, the likelihood of me patronising them drops dramatically."

Third wave

Most of the daily activities that the Kumar family engaged in would have sounded like science fiction 10 years ago. Yet millions of people are living similar lives.

The next revolution in technology, which some are calling 'pervasive computing', attempts to bring computing even closer to our lives. The idea is to put a computer into everything and then hook it up to the Net. Pundits envision that in the next 10 years, thinking appliances, clever clothes and intelligent cars will be commonplace. Whatever the speed and shape of pervasive computing, the hope is that it will keep its main promise: integrating computers and the Internet into devices so imperceptibly that we'll forget they're there!

SRIRAM SHARMA

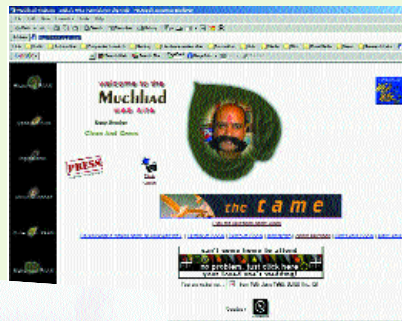
Mucchad, The First Paanwalla on the Web

Jaishankar Tiwari, more popularly known as Mucchad, is a minor celebrity in Warden Road, Mumbai.

What makes this *paanwalla* a legend, apart from his prominent moustache, is that he has his own Web site. He has several enduring fans who swear by his Calcutta *ek sau bees* and *meetha paan*.

Visit www.paan.com, and you can order *paan* or Mucchad special *supari* via e-mail. The site traces the history of *paan* from its origins in the Mughal era and differentiates between the varieties of betel leaves and *paans*, explaining the ingredients that go into making a *paan*.

Mucchad has had people from the US signing his guestbook and placing orders.



He's not quite ready to export *paan* to the US yet, but his site serves as an example of how technology has been adopted even by the layman and not just the English educated urban populace.

Technology and You

How much of a technophile are you? What are the ways you use technology in your daily life? Feel free to share your experiences at readersletters@jasubhai.com.